Ideological rhetoric aside, initially, financial benefits were a big support for the TTP. According to intelligence reports, the TTP was financially supported by Al Qaeda for keeping the security forces of Pakistan engaged so that they could operate around the Pak-Afghan border unchallenged (Hussain, 2011). However, the TTP eventually adopted the enforcement of *Sharia* as its main objective. It was a tactical move to give legitimacy and permanence to its existence. Anti-America stance and rhetoric always remained its stance to cash in the anti-American sentiments in the region.

Within five years, the TTP became the largest organisation of Pakistani militants. It became active in most of the 24 districts, seven tribal agencies and six frontier regions in the North-West Frontier Province. Its strongholds were in South Waziristan, North Waziristan, Orakzai, Kurram, Khyber, Mohmand, Bajaur and Darra Adam Khel tribal regions and in the settled districts of Swat, Upper Dir, Lower Dir, Bannu, Lakki Marwat, Tank, Peshawar, Dera Ismail Khan, Mardan, Charsadda and Kohat (Terrorism Monitor, 2009). South Waziristan, home of Hakimullah, the second chief of TTP, and its HQ, has a very rugged mountainous terrain, an extension of Tora Bora in Afghanistan, making it quite inaccessible, ideal for prolonged guerrilla warfare (Studies in Conflict & Terrorism, 2008).

The TTP's strength in FATA was estimated to be 10,000–35,000 (Council on Foreign Relation, 2009) in 2009. In addition to the TTP, a number of militant groups grew rapidly, mostly to receive foreign funds and to establish their own writ in their respective areas. In 2013, the number of groups directly or indirectly affiliated with the TTP was about 43 and the combined strength of their fighters was approximately 11,000 (*Dawn*, 2013).[1] These included Datta Khel-based Hafiz Gul Bahadur's group, non-Taliban Islamist militant groups in Khyber Agency, mostly in the Bara area like Mangal Bagh's Lashkar-e-Islam, late Haji Namdar's Amr Bil Maruf Wa Nahi Anil Munkar (Promotion of Virtue and Prevention of Vice) and Ustad Mahbub-ul-Haq's Ansar ul Islam (Terrorism Monitor, 2009). They were closely associated with 12 foreign militant groups, including Al Qaeda.

The group of politico-religious parties called Muttahida Majlis-e-Amal (MMA), which had won the elections in NWFP (now Khyber Pakhtunkhwa) with the connivance of General Pervez Musharraf (*Outlook India*, 2003) and ruled the province from 2002 to 2008, had a soft corner